

Egypt



Occupying the northeast corner of Africa, Egypt is divided by the highly fertile Nile Valley. Its essentially pro-Western, military-backed regime is being challenged by Islamic fundamentalists.



GEOGRAPHY

Fertile Nile Valley separates arid Libyan Desert from smaller semiarid eastern desert. Sinai peninsula has mountains in south.



CLIMATE

Summers are very hot, but winters are cooler. Rainfall is negligible, except on the coast.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Despite a long tradition of ethnic and religious tolerance, the rise of Islam has sparked clashes between Muslims and Copts (Coptic Christianity is one of the Church's earliest branches). Women play a full part in education and the economy, though this is threatened by Islamism. Rapidly growing population is a problem. Poverty is rife around Cairo.



INSIGHT: In 450 BCE Herodotus visited the already-ancient pyramids



THE ECONOMY

Oil and gas. Cotton. Tolls from the Suez Canal. Successful tourist industry, in spite of terrorist attacks. High birth-rate and rural poverty.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Arab Republic of Egypt

DATE OF FORMATION: 1936

CAPITAL: Cairo

POPULATION: 83 million

TOTAL AREA: 386,660 sq. miles
(1,001,450 sq. km)

DENSITY: 216 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Arabic*, French, English, Berber

RELIGIONS: Muslim (mainly Sunni) 94%, Coptic Christian and other 6%

ETHNIC MIX: Egyptian 99%, other (Nubian, Armenian, Greek, Berber) 1%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Egyptian pound = 100 piastres